

**GABON**

Capital city: Libreville
Area: 103,346 sq miles (267,667 sq km)
Population: 1,300,000
Official language: French
Major religions: Christian 55%, traditional beliefs 40%, other 5%
Government: Multiparty democracy
Currency: CFA franc
Adult literacy rate: 71%
Life expectancy: 53 years
People per doctor: 5,000
Televisions: 55 per 1,000 people

CONGO

Capital city: Brazzaville
Area: 132,046 sq miles (342,000 sq km)
Population: 3,700,000
Official language: French
Major religions: Traditional beliefs 50%, Christian 48%, Muslim 2%
Government: Multiparty democracy
Currency: CFA franc
Adult literacy rate: 83%
Life expectancy: 52 years
People per doctor: 3,333
Televisions: 12 per 1,000 people

Oil is of vital importance to Congo, bringing in 90 percent of the country's export income.



GABON

SITTING ASTRIDE THE EQUATOR, with plentiful rain all year round, three-quarters of Gabon is covered with tropical rain forest. Lumber is an increasingly valuable resource, although Gabon's biggest earner is oil. This should have made Gabon a wealthy country, but most people are very poor. This is partly because after independence in 1960, a one-party state was created that wasted much of the wealth. In 1990 Gabon became a multiparty democracy.

**PEOPLE**

Although just over 1 million people live in Gabon, there are about 40 different ethnic groups here, each speaking their own dialect. The largest group is the Fang, known for its warriors and skilled wood carvers. Many people in Gabon moved here from other African countries in search of work.

CONGO

CONGO'S EASTERN BORDER follows the course of the Congo River and the Ubangi, its main tributary, or offshoot. Oil reserves have boosted Congo's economy considerably in recent years. Although ordinary people have benefited from this – more than those in Gabon – many still scratch out a living from farming, producing just enough to feed themselves. Cassava, a starchy root vegetable, is the major food crop.

OIL WEALTH

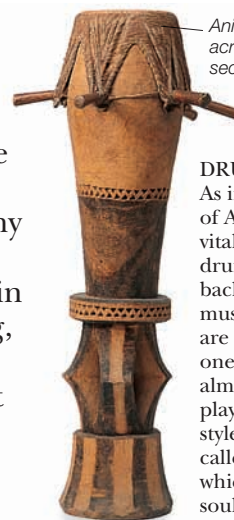
The government has wisely invested the money that comes from oil in the economy, in projects such as dams, paper mills, transportation systems, and reforestation. Although industry is limited, there is a skilled workforce. Most industries are found around the towns and cities, especially Congo's capital, Brazzaville.

**LIBREVILLE**

The capital city, Libreville, means "free town" in French, and was founded in 1849 as a haven for freed slaves. French influence is strong because Gabon was colonized by France during the 1800s. Libreville is a bustling modern city, where some people enjoy great wealth, in contrast to the poverty suffered by most people on the city streets.

MINERAL RICH

Oil and manganese became important exports in the 1960s. This manganese mine is in southeastern Gabon. The country is one of the world's biggest producers of the mineral, which is used to make paints, batteries, and steel. There are also plentiful reserves of iron ore and other metals, but these have yet to be developed to their full potential.



Animal skin stretched across the top and secured with pegs

DRUMBEAT

As in other parts of Africa, music is a vital part of life, and drumbeats form the backbone of this music. Many drums are wooden, and the one shown here is almost as tall as its players. One popular style in the region is called Congo music, which is similar to soul music.

Find out more

CASSAVA: 221, 240
 OIL: 152, 230, 281
 POLITICAL SYSTEMS: 270–271
 RAIN FORESTS: 15, 69, 204